

Week 7: Gettysburg, Pennsylvania/Vicksburg, Mississippi

Question

1. Josiah Gorgas, a Confederate official, wrote this in his diary on July 28th, 1863:

Events have succeeded one another with disastrous rapidity. One brief month ago we were apparently at the point of success. Lee was in Pennsylvania, Harrisburg, and even Philadelphia. Vicksburg seemed to laugh all Grant's efforts to scorn....Now the picture is just as sombre as it was bright then....It seems incredible that human power could effect such a change in so brief a space. Yesterday we rode on the pinnacle of success—today absolute ruin seems to be our portion. The Confederacy totters to its destruction.

Using your reading and this week's lectures, explain how Gorgas' high expectations for Confederate success was dashed by the two Union victories at Gettysburg and Vicksburg. In your opinion, how did military success or failure specifically affect the morale of the homefronts? Use specific examples in your answer.

Key Terms

- Fredericksburg
- George Gordon Meade
- The Pennsylvania Campaign
- Rebel Yell
- James Longstreet
- The Gettysburg Address
- The Vicksburg Campaign
- Mississippi River
- John Pemberton
- The Siege of Vicksburg

Lee Moves North

THE ENEMY
IS
APPROACHING!
I MUST RELY UPON THE PEOPLE FOR THE
DEFENCE OF THE STATE!
AND HAVE
CALLED THE MILITIA
FOR THAT PURPOSE.
the term of service will only be while the danger to the State
is imminent.
 **Send forward Companies**
AS SOON AS POSSIBLE
Signed, **ANDREW G. CURTIN.**



Warnings of a coming military storm began to appear throughout Pennsylvania (above), as emergency militia, like the minutemen of old, formed units. In early June, the first of Confederate General Robert E. Lee's men began to march from Fredericksburg, Va. through the Shenandoah Valley. "The morale of the army was superb," remembered a young rebel soldier; "officers and men alike inspired with confidence in the ability of the army to beat its old antagonist anywhere he chose to meet us."

Among the militia units raised was the 26th Pennsylvania, which included a company from the small but prosperous town of Gettysburg (left). Little did these men know that they would soon be fighting the enemy in—quite literally—their own backyard.

Lee's Invasion of Pennsylvania

Timeline

April 30-May 6:

Gen. Robert E. Lee inflicts a crushing defeat upon the Union's Army of the Potomac at the Battle of Chancellorsville in Virginia. However, Lee's most trusted lieutenant—Lt. Gen. Thomas J. "Stonewall" Jackson—is badly wounded.

May 10:

Jackson dies and Lee decides to reorganize the Army of Northern Virginia. What was two corps commanded by Jackson and Lt. Gen. James Longstreet becomes three corps commanded by Longstreet, Lt. Gen. Richard Ewell, and Lt. Gen. A.P. Hill.

June 9:

Federal cavalry under Brig. Gen. Alfred Pleasonton surprises Confederate Maj. Gen. J.E.B. Stuart's cavalry at Brandy Station, and the biggest cavalry battle of the war ensues

June 13:

Union Maj. Gen. Joseph Hooker withdraws the Army of the Potomac from Fredericksburg, Va. and retreats northwards

June 15:

Confederate troops begin to cross the Potomac River

June 25:

Stuart leads his cavalry away from the main Confederate force, intending to reunite with Lee at York, Pa.

June 26:

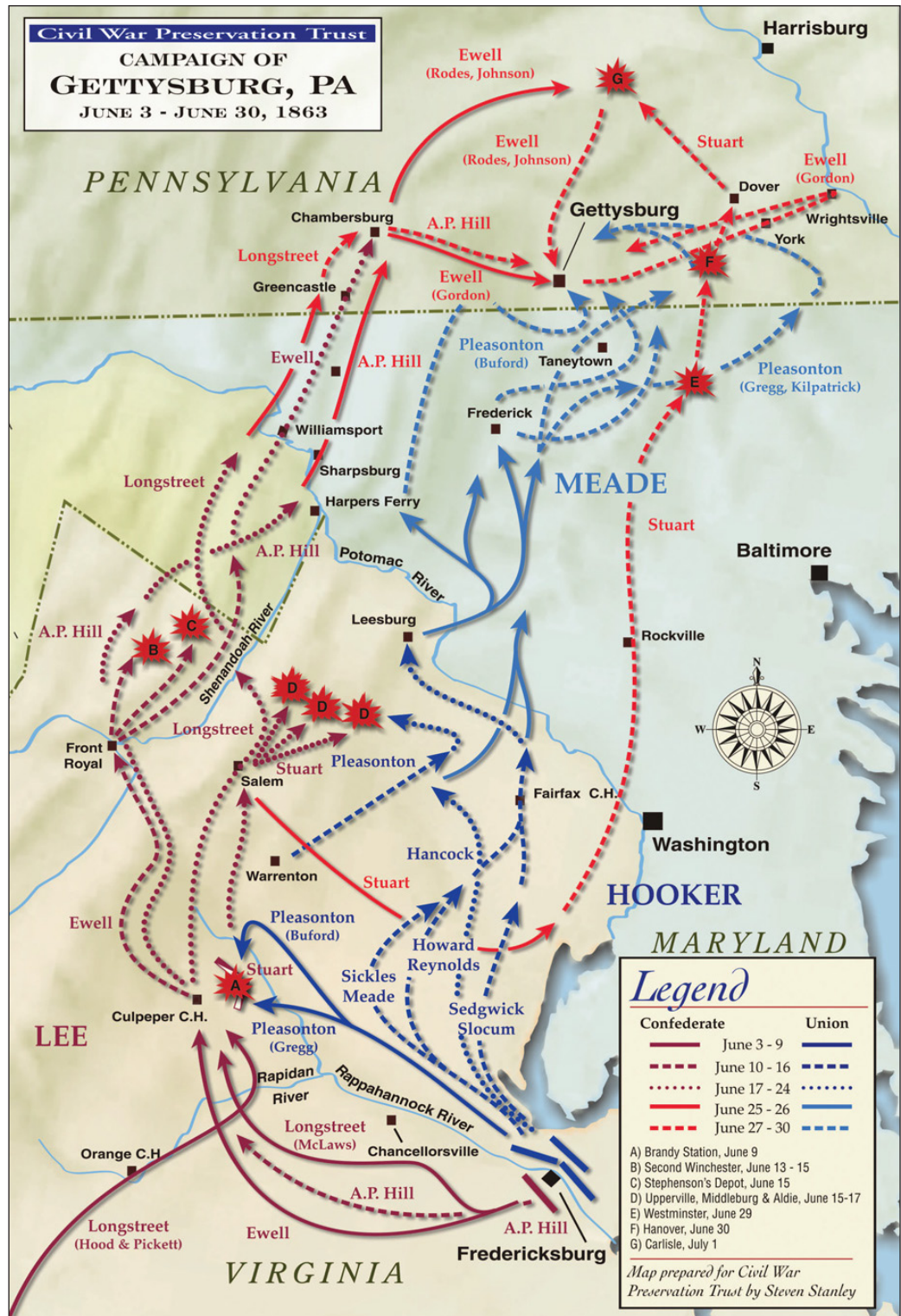
Hooker is relieved of command of the Army of the Potomac and is replaced by Maj. Gen. George Gordon Meade

June 30:

Cavalry skirmish at Hanover, Pa.

June 30:

Meade orders Maj. Gen. John Reynolds to Gettysburg.



Oh, I wish he were ours!

- A Northern woman, as Robert E. Lee rode through her hometown in Maryland on June 26, 1863, following a string of impressive victories for the general and his Army of Northern Virginia



Gen. Robert E. Lee and Lt. Gen. James Longstreet discuss strategy before the Battle of Gettysburg, as imagined by an artist more than a century after the Civil War reached its conclusion.

Timeline

7:30 a.m.:

Confederate troops under Maj. Gen. Henry Heth encounter Union troops commanded by Brig. Gen. William Gamble, and steady skirmishing develops.

8:00 a.m.:

Union Brig. Gen. Abner Doubleday's I Corps and Maj. Gen. O.O. Howard's XI Corps move toward Gettysburg

8:30 a.m.:

Word reaches Confederate Lt. Gen. Richard S. Ewell of the engagement at Gettysburg. He changes direction towards Gettysburg, and his corps begins to arrive around 1:00 p.m.

10:15 a.m.:

Union Maj. Gen. John Reynolds arrives and assumes command of the Union forces on the field

10:50 a.m.:

Reynolds is shot and killed

11:30 a.m.:

Howard arrives in Gettysburg and takes command of Union forces

3:30 p.m.:

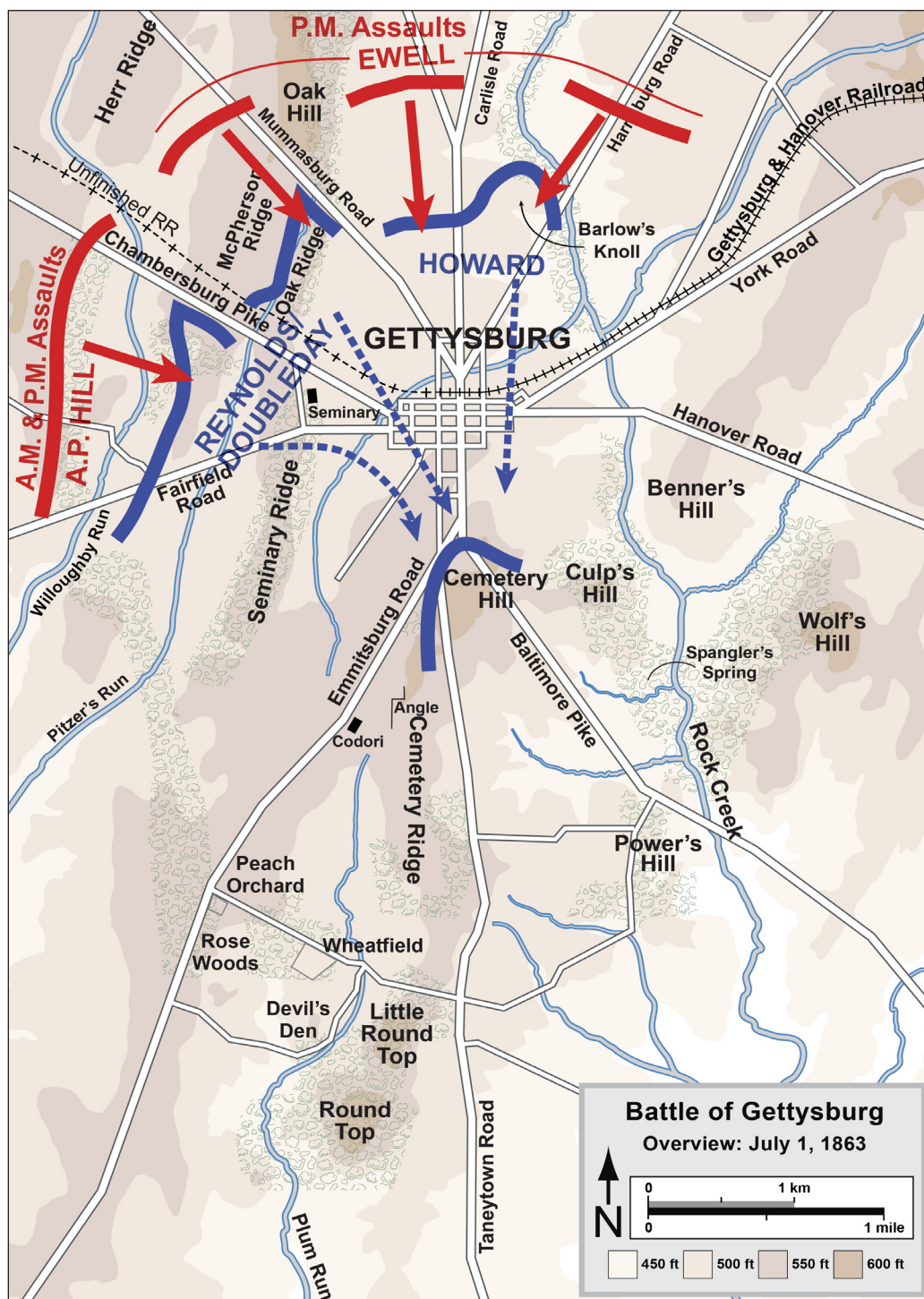
The arrival of Confederate reinforcements compels the Federals to retreat through Gettysburg and to begin establishing defensive positions along Cemetery Ridge, to the southeast of the town

4:30 p.m.:

Gen. Robert E. Lee arrives in Gettysburg. Not knowing the condition of Ewell's corps, he sends Ewell an order to take Cemetery Hill "if practicable." Ewell decides an attack is not practicable.

6:00 p.m.:

Maj. Gen. George Gordon Meade orders the entire Army of the Potomac to move to Gettysburg



For seven or eight minutes ensued probably the most desperate fight ever waged between artillery and infantry at close range with a particle of cover on either side, bullets hissing, humming and whistling everywhere; cannon roaring; all crash on crash and peal on peal, smoke, dust, splinters, blood, wreck and carnage indescribable.

- Corp. Augustus Buell, USA



George Gordon Meade at his headquarters during the Battle of Gettysburg. He had been reluctant to accept command of the Army of the Potomac, and had been in the position for less than a week when the battle began.

Timeline

4:00 a.m.:

Maj. Gen. George Gordon Meade arrives at Cemetery Hill and takes command of the Union Army. He decides to hold the ground and fight at Gettysburg

5:30 a.m.:

Gen. Robert E. Lee and Lt. Gen. James Longstreet debate tactics. Longstreet expresses a desire to maneuver around the enemy; Lee states his preference for an attack. Longstreet is compelled to defer.

9:00 a.m.:

Lee rides to Lt. Gen. Richard Ewell's headquarters and tells him to begin his attack when he hears Longstreet attack

Noon:

Longstreet begins his march toward the Union left flank; Maj. Gen. J.E.B. Stuart finally arrives at Gettysburg

12:30 p.m.:

Longstreet discovers that his planned line of march will be visible to the Union army, spoiling the surprise of his flank attack. He is forced take a different, concealed approach

4:00 p.m.:

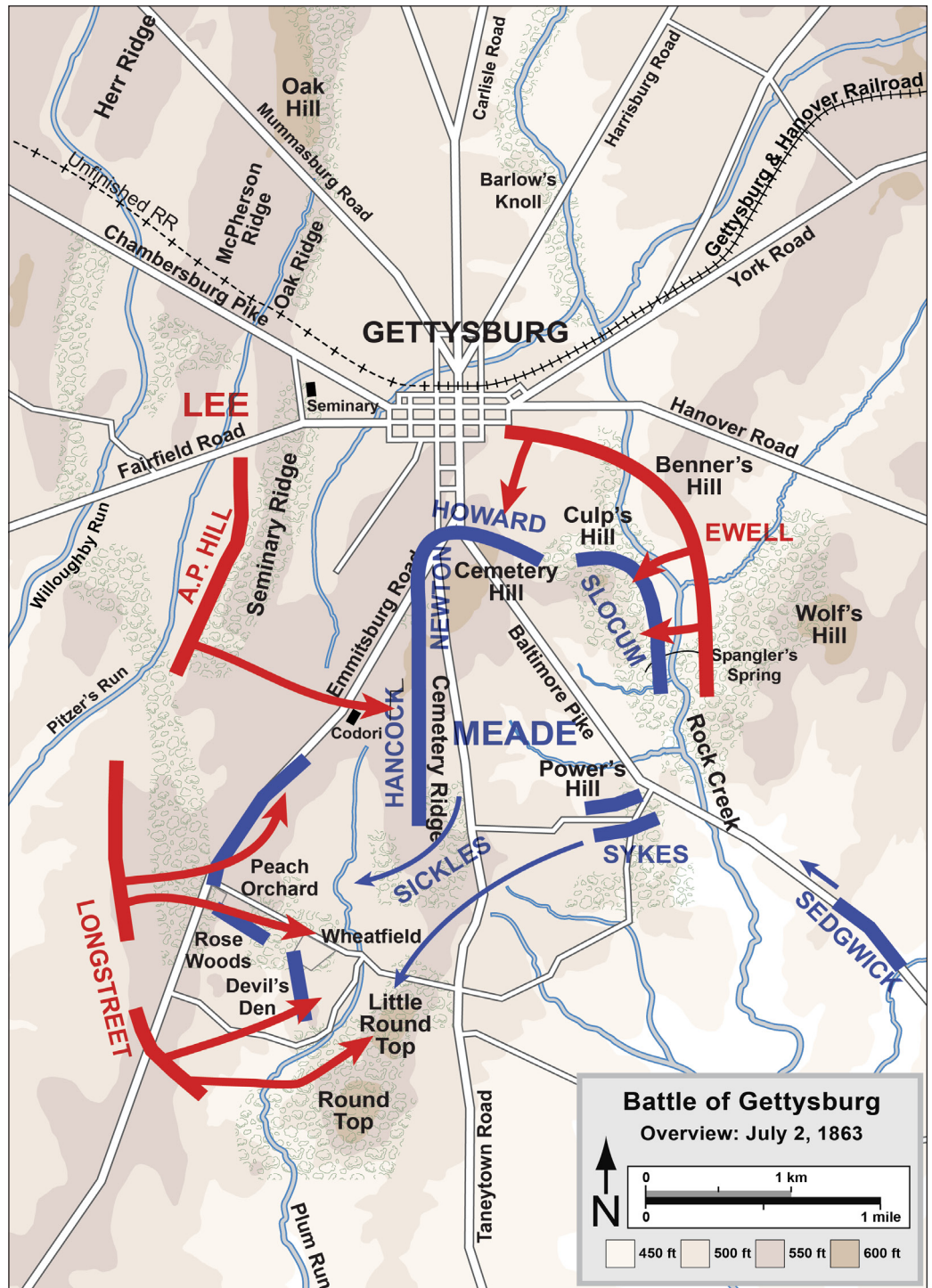
Confederate Maj. Gen. John Bell Hood's Division attacks the Union at Devil's Den and Little Round Top. The Union falls back a bit, but then holds for about an hour and a half.

5:00 p.m. - 11:00 p.m.:

Heavy fighting at Culp's Hill (northern end of Union line), as well as the Peach Orchard and Little Round Top (southern end of Union line).

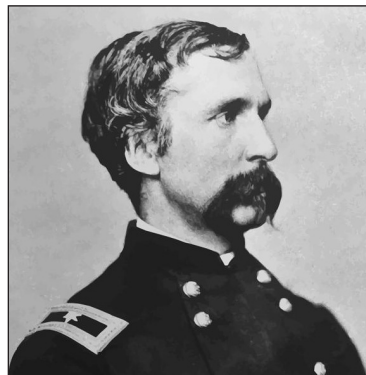
11:30 p.m.:

It is evident that while Ewell's and Longstreet's attacks have done much damage, the Union line remains firm



The two lines met and broke and mingled in the shock. The crush of musketry gave way to cuts and thrusts, grapplings and wrestlings. The edge of conflict swayed to and fro, with wild whirlpools and eddies. At times I saw around me more of the enemy than of my own men; gaps opening, swallowing, closing again with sharp convulsive energy...How men held on, each one knows—not I. But manhood commands admiration.

- Lt. Col. Joshua L. Chamberlain, USA



Thanks to his leadership of the 20th Maine Infantry during the defense of Little Round Top, university professor-turned-soldier Joshua Lawrence Chamberlain became one of the great heroes of the Battle of Gettysburg, and of the Civil War.

Timeline

1:00 a.m.:

Gen. Robert E. Lee sends orders to Lt. Gens. James Longstreet and Richard Ewell to renew their attacks on the Union flanks at dawn. Ewell prepares to carry the order out; Longstreet, apparently, never receives it

6:00 a.m.:

Lee meets with Longstreet, who is making preparations to move his divisions south of Round Top for a flanking attack. Lee cancels plans for a morning attack (too late for Ewell, whose attack is underway) and considers other options

8:30 a.m.:

Satisfied that no better plan is available, Lee orders Longstreet to attack the center of Cemetery Ridge with Maj. Gen. Henry Heth's Division, two brigades of Maj. Gen. William Pender's Division, and Maj. Gen. George E. Pickett's Division. Longstreet protests that the attack cannot possibly succeed.

1:15 p.m.:

Confederate artillery on Seminary Ridge opens fire on Cemetery Ridge to prepare the way for the coming attack

2:30 p.m.:

The Confederates commence their attack on Cemetery Hill

3:00 p.m.:

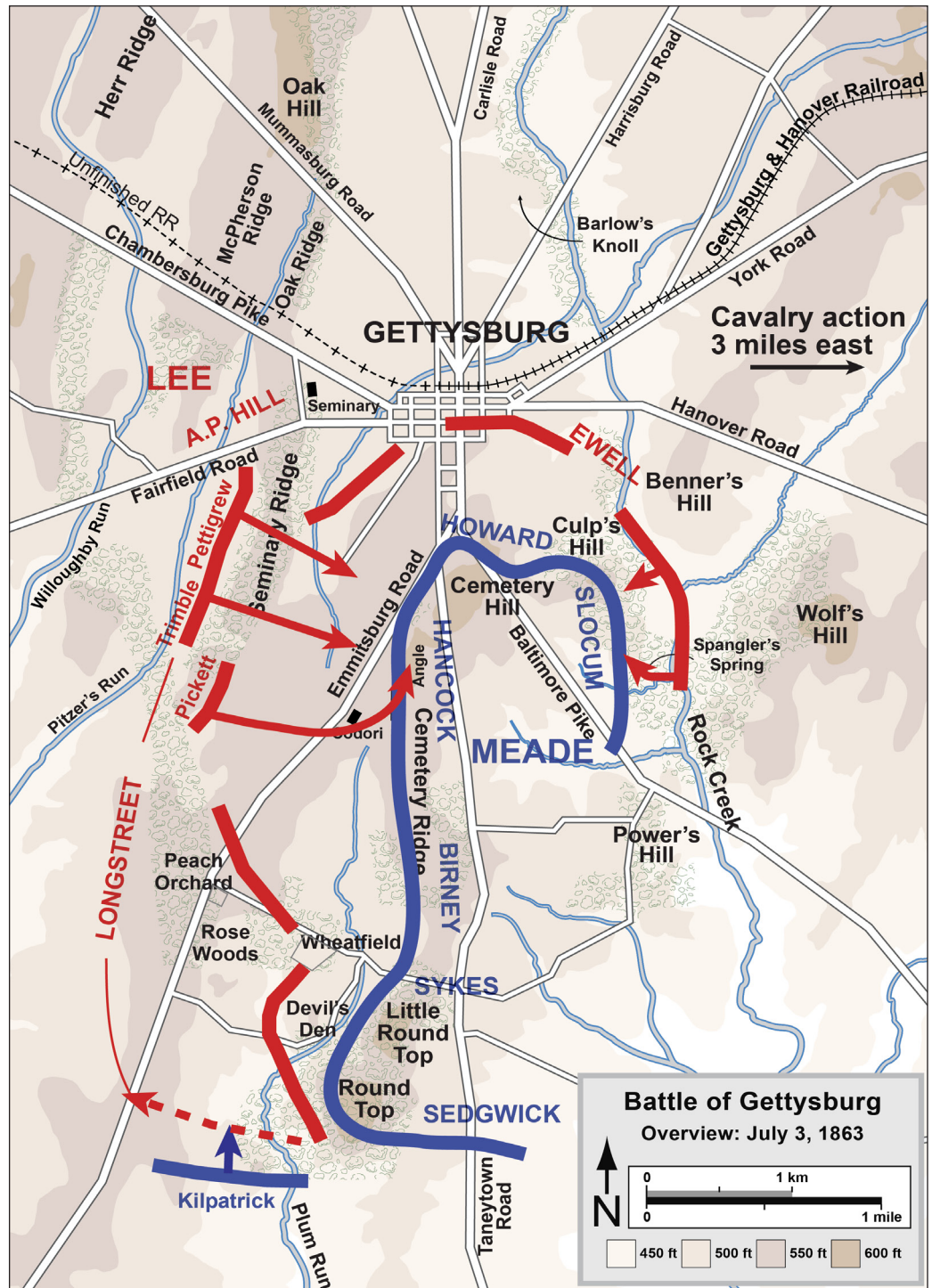
The flank brigades of "Pickett's Charge" are forced to halt by fire from Union troops in advanced positions along the Emmitsburg Road. The other brigades advance to Cemetery Ridge but cannot reach the Union line and are compelled to retreat

7:00 p.m.:

Maj. Gen. George Gordon Meade decides against a counterattack

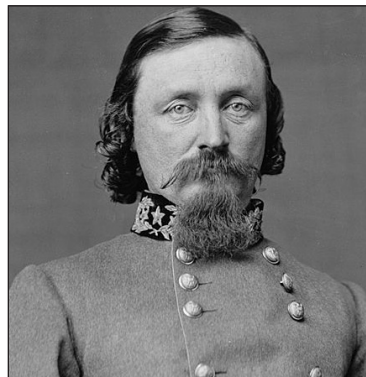
11:00 p.m.:

Lee, after consulting with his corps commanders, decides to retreat. The Battle of Gettysburg is over



I can still hear them cheering as I gave the order, "Forward!" the thrill of their joyous voices as they called out, "We'll follow you, Marse George, we'll follow you!" On, how faithfully they followed me on-on-to their death, and I led them on-on-on-Oh God!

- Maj. Gen. George E. Pickett, CSA



Though there were actually three generals who led troops during the climactic assault made by the Confederates against the center of the Union line on the third day of the Battle of Gettysburg, it was Maj. Gen. George E. Pickett who was forever immortalized by the charge that now bears his name.



On November 19, 1863, Abraham Lincoln came to Gettysburg to dedicate the new Union cemetery. The featured speaker was to be Edward Everett, the former governor of Massachusetts, diplomat, clergyman, politician, and now, at seventy, best known for his lush, patriotic oratory. The President had been asked only to offer a few “appropriate remarks.”

A crowd of nearly six thousand gathered to hear the speeches, and local entrepreneurs set up tables on the cemetery’s outskirts to sell cookies and lemonade and battle relics—minie balls, canteens, buttons, and dried wildflowers grown on the battlefield and preserved in daguerreotype cases.

Everett was introduced, and launched into a speech that lasted one hour and fifty-seven minutes. While he listened, the President fussed with the wording of his own remarks.

Finally, Lincoln rose to speak:

Four score and seven years ago our fathers brought forth on this continent a new nation, conceived in liberty and dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal.

Now we are engaged in a great civil war, testing whether that nation or any nation so conceived and so dedicated can long endure. We are met on a great battlefield of that war. We have come to dedicate a portion of that field as a final resting-place for those who here gave their lives that that nation might live. It is altogether fitting and proper that we should do this.

But in a larger sense, we cannot dedicate, we cannot consecrate, we cannot hallow this ground. The brave men, living and dead who struggled here have consecrated it far above our poor power to add or detract. The world will little note nor long remember what we say here, but it can never forget what they did here. It is for us the living rather to be dedicated here to the unfinished work which they who fought here have thus far so nobly advanced. It is rather for us to be here dedicated to the great task remaining before us—that from these honored dead we take increased devotion to that cause for which they gave the last full measure of devotion—that we here highly resolve that these dead shall not have died in vain, that this nation under God shall have a new birth of freedom, and that government of the people, by the people, for the people shall not perish from the earth.

Lincoln was displeased with his performance. “That speech won’t scour,” his friend Ward Hill Lamon remembered him saying. “It’s a flat failure.” The correspondent for the London Times agreed: “The ceremony was rendered ludicrous by...the sallies of that poor President Lincoln...Anyone more dull and commonplace it would not be easy to produce.”

But Edward Everett felt different. “I should flatter myself that I came as near to the central idea of the occasion, in two hours, as you did in two minutes.”

Grant's First Vicksburg Campaign: November 1862-January 1863

Timeline

November 3-4, 1862:

Maj. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant's center wing moves south; two wings of his Army of the Tennessee rendezvous at Grand Junction

November 26:

Maj. Gen. William T. Sherman, commanding Grant's right wing, marches Southeast from Memphis, Tenn.

November 27:

Grant's center and left wings advance south, occupy Holly Springs, Miss. and approach the Tallahatchie crossings

November 29-December 5:

Confederates retreat from Tallahatchie and move 50 miles south to the Yalobusha River

December 11-21:

Confederate cavalry successfully disrupt Grant's lines of supply

December 20:

Confederate Maj. Gen. Earl Van Dorn's troops destroy Grant's Holly Springs depot

December 29:

After two days of skirmishing, Sherman attacks the Confederates at Chickasaw Bayou in Miss., but is repulsed and compelled to retreat to Milliken's Bend, La.

Late December:

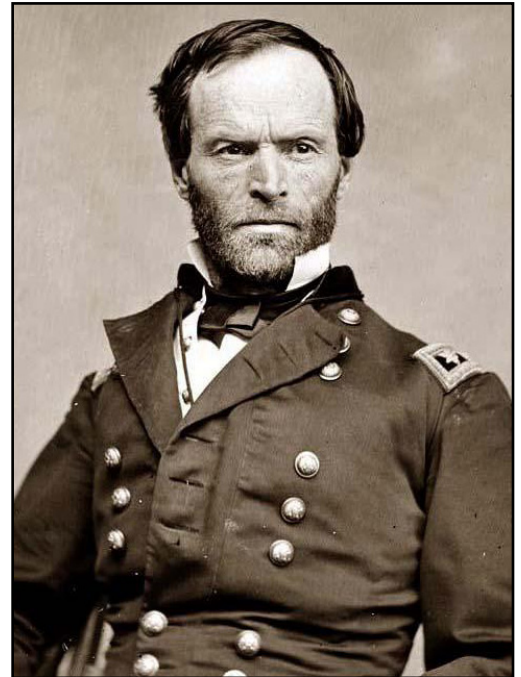
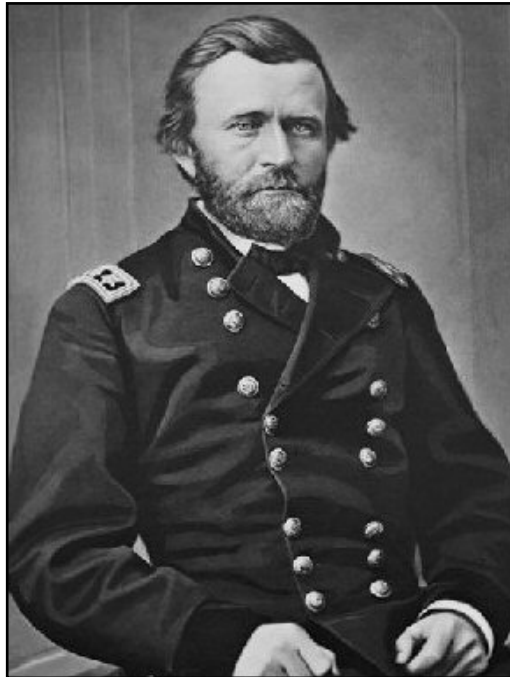
Confederates reinforce Vicksburg

December 22-January 10, 1863:

With the destruction of his depot and supply line, Grant withdraws across the Tallahatchie, arriving at Memphis, Tenn. on January 10

January 9-11:

Union forces ascend the Arkansas River and capture Arkansas Post

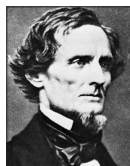


Maj. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant (top left) was notable for his dogged determination, and his willingness to work with whatever resources he was given. Maj. Gen. William T. Sherman was Grant's right-hand man, and enjoyed his commander's full confidence, despite having once been removed from command on charges of insanity. The two men worked together very well during the campaign against Vicksburg (below, as it appeared in 1861), and would go on to crush the remaining Confederate armies, earning the sobriquet "the partnership that won the war."



Vicksburg is the key! The war can never be brought to a close until that key is in our pocket... We can take all the northern ports of the Confederacy, and they can defy us from Vicksburg. It means ... fresh troops from the states of the far south, and a cotton country where they can raise the staple without interference.

- President Abraham Lincoln, USA



Vicksburg is the nailhead that holds the South's two halves together ... Vicksburg is the key

- President Jefferson Davis, CSA

Grant's Second Vicksburg Campaign, Phase 1: January—May 1863

Timeline

January 30, 1863:

Maj. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant establishes his headquarters at Milliken's Bend, La.

February 3:

Union troops breach levee at Yazoo Pass and gain access to Moon Lake and Coldwater River

February 23-March 10:

Union boats navigate Yazoo Pass and descend Coldwater and Tallahatchie Rivers

March 16-27:

Gunboats under the command of Union Adm. David Dixon Porter, aided by troops from Maj. Gen. William T. Sherman's command, attempt to reach Vicksburg from the northwest, but are forced to turn back

March 11-April 4:

Confederates in Fort

April 17-May 2:

Union Brig. Gen. Benjamin H. Grierson's cavalry "dashes" from La Grange, Tenn. to Baton Rouge, La., diverting attention from Grant's army while it marches southward

April 29-May 1:

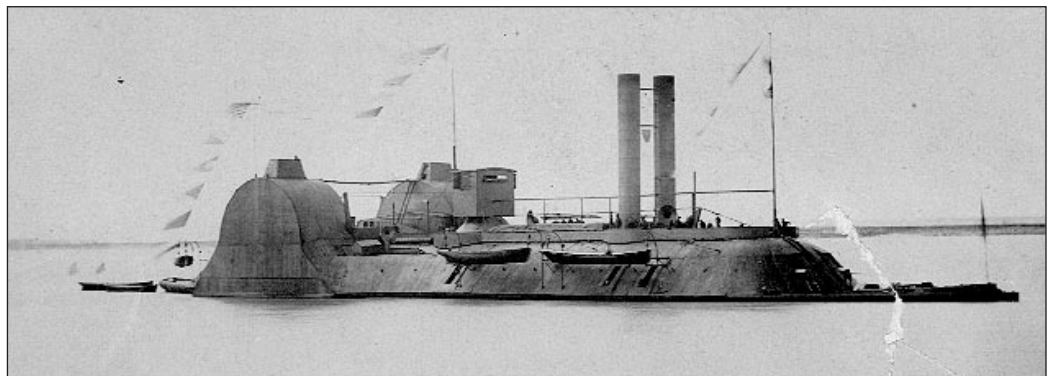
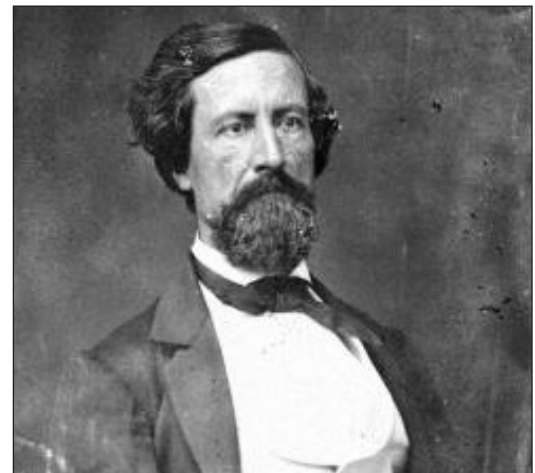
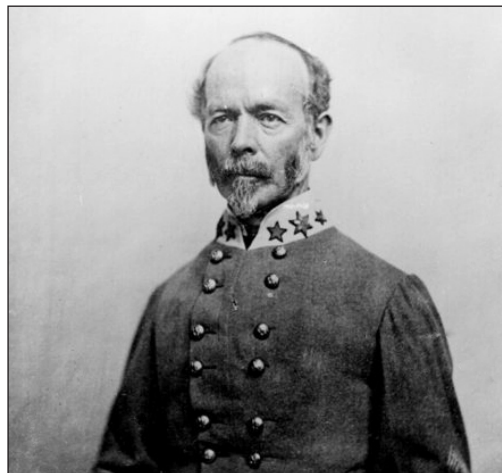
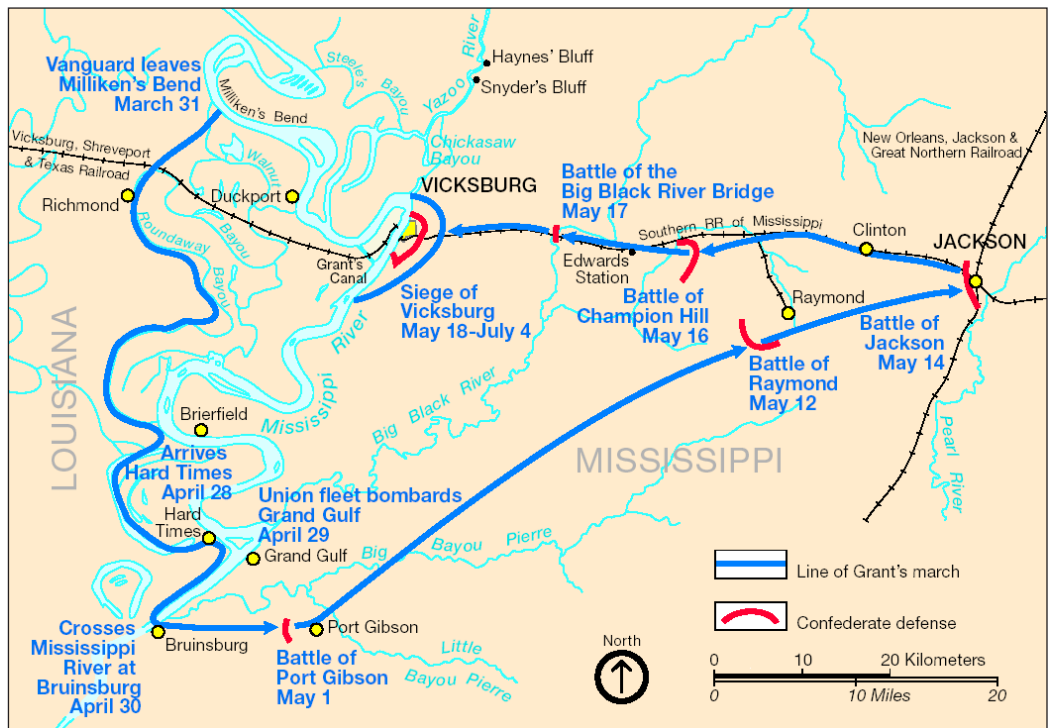
Sherman's troops ascend the Yazoo River and distract the Confederates' attention from the spot where Grant intends to cross the Mississippi River

May 1:

Grant decides against crossing the Mississippi at Grand Gulf, Miss., and instead decides to make a crossing at Bruinsburg, Miss.

May 1:

Union victory near Port Gibson secures beachhead; Confederate forces retreat across the Bayou Pierre



Responsibility for defending Vicksburg devolved upon Confederate Lt. Gens. Joseph E. Johnston (top left) and John C. Pemberton (top right), with Pemberton having ultimate authority over the city. Abrupt and domineering in manner, Pemberton was not popular with his soldiers or his colleagues, but he did enjoy the support of President Jefferson Davis.

The Union advance against Vicksburg was aided substantially by ironclad ships, including the *USS Lafayette* (below).

Grant's Second Vicksburg Campaign, Phase 2: May 2-17, 1863

Timeline

May 2, 1863:

Union Maj. Gen. James B. McPherson's troops cross Little Bayou Pierre in La. and march to Grindstone Ford in Miss.

May 2-3:

Confederate troops evacuate Grand Gulf, Miss.

May 3:

Union troops advance to the Big Black River and seize a beachhead. Maj. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant's army and Adm. David Dixon Porter's fleet rendezvous at Grand Gulf

May 3-8:

Maj. Gen. William T. Sherman's troops march from Milliken's Bend, La. and join with Grant's forces

May 8-11:

Grant's troops advance up the Big Black Bayou watershed

May 13:

Grant changes course and strikes east toward Jackson, Miss.

May 14:

Forces under the command of Union Maj. Gens. Sherman and James B. McPherson compel the Confederates to evacuate Jackson

May 15:

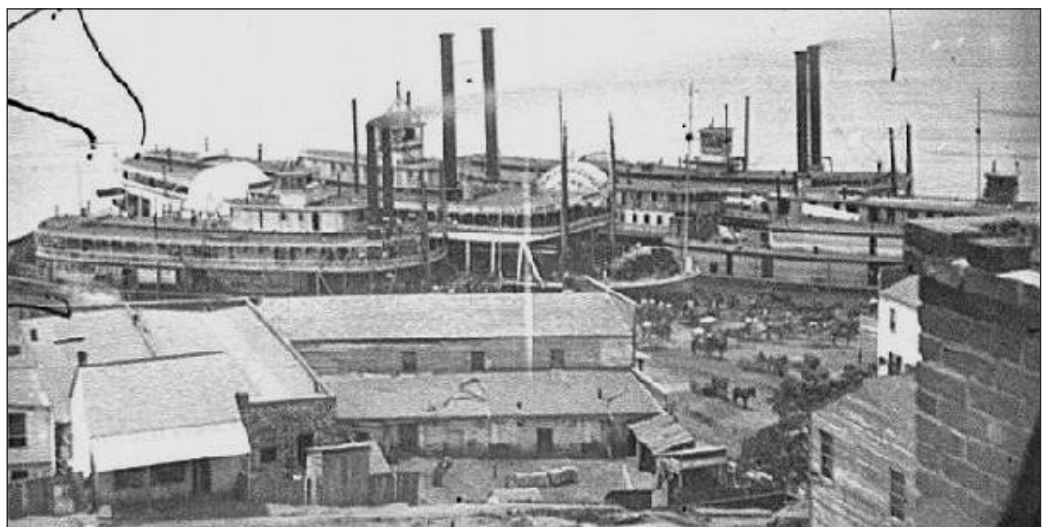
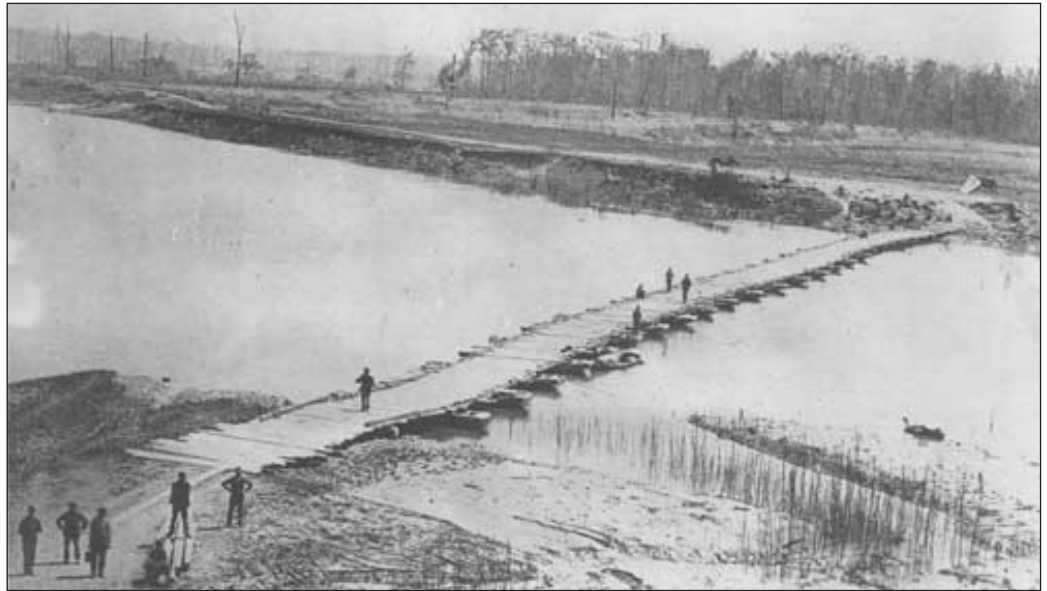
Sherman's troops destroy Jackson's railroads while seven Union divisions under McPherson and Maj. Gen. John McClernand move east to engage Confederate Lt. Gen. John C. Pemberton

May 16:

Union troops defeat Pemberton at Champion's Hill, Miss.

May 17:

Confederates at Big Black are routed, McPherson and Sherman prepare to cross the river



Maj. Gen. William T. Sherman's troops crossed the Big Black River on pontoon bridges during their move toward Vicksburg in May 1863 (top). Maj. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant used a modest house as his headquarters during much of the Vicksburg campaign (center). Adm. David Dixon Porter's fleet (bottom) played a key role in facilitating Grant's march against, and siege of, Vicksburg.

The Siege and Capture of Vicksburg: May 18-July 4, 1863

Timeline

May 18, 1863:

Confederates occupy Vicksburg and dramatically strengthen its defenses

May 17-19:

Maj. Gen. Ulysses S. Grant's army approaches Vicksburg, including Maj. Gen. William T. Sherman's troops via Benton and Graveyard Roads, Maj. Gen. James B. McPherson's troops via Jackson Road, and Maj. Gen. John McClernand's troops via Baldwin's Ferry Road

May 19:

Grant's force attacks Vicksburg, but is repulsed

May 20-22:

Grant deploys artillery and occupies ground closer to Vicksburg's perimeter

May 22, morning:

Union artillery, aided by gunboats under the command of Adm. David Dixon Porter, bombard Vicksburg

May 22, afternoon:

Grant's and Porter's forces attack the Confederate defenses of Vicksburg; both are repulsed with heavy losses

May 25:

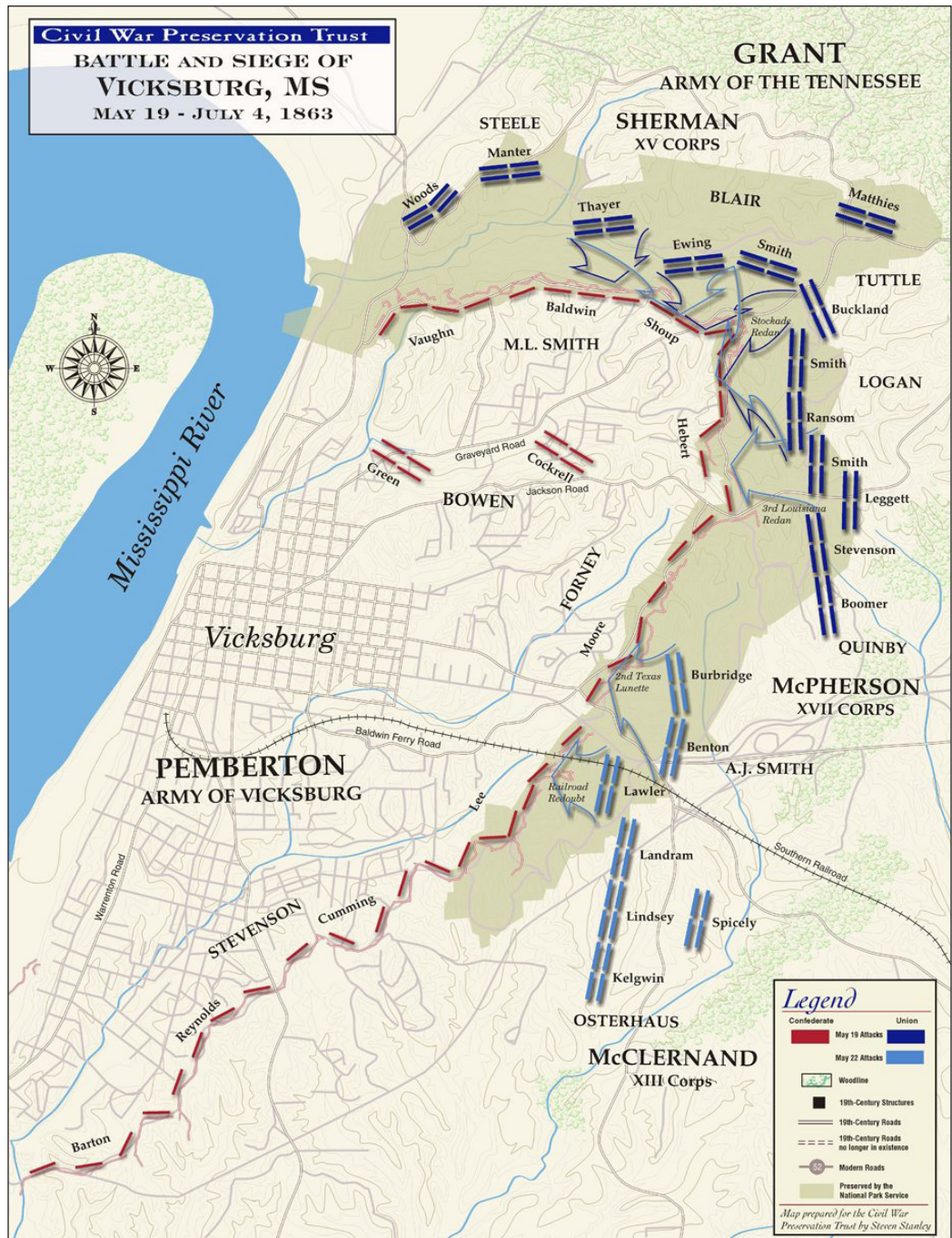
Concluding that the Confederates' defenses are too strong to be breached, Grant orders his troops to begin siege operations and arranges for reinforcements

May 25-July 4:

Union forces forge an iron-clad ring around Vicksburg, sealing the Confederate forces within the town

July 4:

With supplies and morale dwindling, Confederate commander Lt. Gen. John C. Pemberton surrenders Vicksburg to Grant



Bill of Fare for the "Hotel de Vicksburg," July 1863

SOUP Mule Tail	SIDE DISHES Mule salad Mule hoof soused Mule brains a-la-omelette Mule kidney stuffed with peas Mule tripe fried in pea meal batter Mule tongue cold a-la-Bray	DES(S)ERT. White-oak acorns Beech nuts Blackberry leaf tea Genuine Confederate Coffee
ROAST Mule sirloin. Mule rump stuffed with rice	JELLIES Mule foot	LIQUORS Mississippi water, vintage of 1848, superior, \$3.00 Limestone water, late importation, very fine, \$2.75 Spring water, Vicksburg brand, \$1.50
VEGETABLES Peas and rice	PASTRY Pea meal pudding, blackberry sauce Cotton-wood berry pies China Berry tart	Meals at all hours Gentlemen to wait upon themselves
ENTREES Mule head stuffed a-la-mode Mule beef jerked a-la-Mexicana Mule ears fricassee a-la-gotch Mule side stewed, new style, hair on		

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